



Hassle-free Flying

THEN: It took at least 25-30 minutes for baggages to reach conveyer belts

NOW: Domestic bags will arrive in 10 minutes, last bag in 30 minutes; international first bag in 15 minutes, last bag in 40 minutes

THEN: Drivers took 15-20 minutes to find a parking spot

NOW: They will take less than five minutes to find parking space and even exit the parking

THEN: It took a passenger at least 20 minutes to get a taxi

NOW: Passengers will have to wait less than three minutes for taxis

THEN: There was no accommodation at the airport in case of flight delays

NOW: There will be a 60-room transit hotel at the terminal

THEN: It took 45 minutes to clear immigration, security and customs

NOW: The passengers will have to wait less than 10 minutes at each

such as Spicejet, Indigo and Go Air. There are 168 check-in counters, 97 walkways and 14 baggage reclaim belts, all of which will help reduce waiting time. The baggage handling system is run by Siemens, which operates the same at the new Beijing Airport, where 12,500 bags are scanned every hour. Delhi International Airport (P) Ltd (DIAL), the GMR subsidiary that is building the airport, itself will have the capacity to handle 12,800 bags per hour and as there is almost complete automation it will minimise the incidence of damage, loss or mishandling of baggage. "We will make our systems more process-oriented rather than people-oriented," says Rao. Passengers will take less than 45 minutes on arrival, less than 10 minutes each at immigration, security and customs, and the maximum queuing time at check-in

TERMINAL 3 WILL CATER TO DOMESTIC AS WELL AS INTERNATIONAL PASSENGERS

will be less than 20 minutes and five minutes for economy and business class passengers respectively.

DIAL's runway to success has not been without hitches, however. In 2005, the bids for Delhi and Mumbai airport projects ran into turbulent weather as the political opposition cited a lack of transparency and demanded that the modernisation contract be given to the Airports Authority of India (AAI). However, the final rights to operate and manage the Delhi airport went to GMR following an order by the Supreme Court. Armed with the order, DIAL teams spread out across the globe, studying some of the best airports. These included Incheon in Seoul, Suvarnabhumi in Bangkok, Narita in Tokyo, Heathrow in London and air-

ports in Kuala Lumpur, Madrid, Frankfurt, Dubai and Hong Kong. "We had the chance of learning from others' strengths and weaknesses," says Rao. For instance, Incheon is known for its smooth process flow (it takes the airport roughly 10 seconds against the 1.09 minutes conventional immigration processes consume), Changi for its ambience, Hong Kong for its connectivity and Heathrow airport (Terminal 5) on how to avoid blunders.

Originally, AAI had projected passenger traffic of 20 million a year in 2012. Six months later, a study by Mott MacDonald revised the estimate to 37 million. This meant that the building had to be twice the size of the originally planned 2,50,000 sq m. Also, as per the contract, 90 per cent of the passengers had to move through the aerobridges, which itself was a huge task. Moreover,